



Restoring Digital Trust: A Practical Deepfake Detection System to Combat Misinformation in the Age of Synthetic Media.

AMEER WISAM ABDULSATTAR

ALI JAWAD GATA.

Mohammed Taleb Sabbar

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Supervisor

Assist. Prof. Dr. Ahmed Saadi

COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING
AL_ MUTHANNA UNIVERSITY

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I hereby declare that I have read this thesis and, in my opinion, this thesis is sufficient in terms of scope and quality for the award of the degree of Bachelor in Electronics and Communication Engineering.

Signature :

Name of Supervisor : Assist. Prof. Dr. Ahmed Saadi

Date : 22 April 2026

DECLARATION

We declare that this report, entitled “Restoring Digital Trust: A Practical Deepfake Detection System to Combat Misinformation in the Age of Synthetic Media,” is the result of our own research except as cited in the references. The report has not been accepted for any degree and is not concurrently submitted in candidature for any other degree.

Signature :

Name : AMEER WISAM ABDULSATTAR

Date : APRIL 2026

Signature :

Name : ALI JAWAD GATA

Date : APRIL 2026

Signature :

Name : Mohammed Taleb Sabbar

Date : APRIL 2026

DEDICATION

We dedicate this humble work first to Allah Almighty, the source of light and guidance, who granted us strength, patience, and determination throughout our studies, and helped us complete this research and overcome the challenges we faced along the way.

To our dear parents, the heartbeat of our lives, and our first support in this world, who gave everything they had to ensure our education and provided the right environment for our success and excellence. You have been the true motivation behind every achievement we accomplish.

To our brothers, sisters, and honorable family, who have always supported and assisted us with their prayers, encouragement, and standing by us through every step of the way.

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ABSTRACT

The rapid proliferation of AI-synthesized media, commonly known as deepfakes, poses a critical threat to digital integrity by enabling the spread of disinformation and facilitating targeted cyber-extortion. This paper proposes a Hybrid Spatiotemporal Deep Learning Framework for robust deepfake detection, built upon a hierarchical feature extraction pipeline that integrates three complementary architectures: ResNet-18 for spatial frame-level feature extraction, a Bidirectional Long Short-Term Memory (Bi-LSTM) network for short-term temporal inconsistency modeling, and a Transformer encoder leveraging self-attention mechanisms for long-range contextual analysis. The system was trained and evaluated on the Celeb-DF-v2 benchmark dataset comprising 2,108 test samples (53.6% fake, 46.4% real), using a face-centric preprocessing pipeline that incorporates MTCNN-based face detection, normalization, and data augmentation, complemented by unsupervised PCA and K-Means analysis for feature space exploration. The proposed ResNet-18 + Transformer Encoder model was benchmarked against two comparative architectures: Model 1 (ResNet-18 + Bi-LSTM) achieved 97.63% accuracy with a fake recall of 99.12%; the baseline Model 3 (ResNet-18 + RNN) recorded 97.96% accuracy; while the proposed Model 2 (ResNet-18 + Transformer) attained 97.87% accuracy with the lowest false alarm rate of 2.86% and the highest real-class recall of 97.14%, demonstrating the optimal balance between detection sensitivity and operational reliability. The experimental results validate the necessity of spatiotemporal modeling for detecting high-fidelity deepfakes and confirm the framework's readiness for real-world deployment in media verification, digital forensics, and content moderation applications.

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List Of Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Full Term
AI	Artificial Intelligence
AMP	Automated Mixed Precision
AUC	Area Under the Curve
BCE	Binary Cross-Entropy
Bi-LSTM	Bidirectional Long Short-Term Memory
CGI	Computer-Generated Imagery
CNN	Convolutional Neural Network
CUDA	Compute Unified Device Architecture
DCT	Discrete Cosine Transform
DDPM	Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Model
DFDC	DeepFake Detection Challenge
F1-Score	F-Measure / Harmonic mean of precision and recall
FPR	False Positive Rate
GAN	Generative Adversarial Network
GPU	Graphics Processing Unit
LDM	Latent Diffusion Model
LSTM	Long Short-Term Memory
MTCNN	Multi-task Cascaded Convolutional Networks
NLP	Natural Language Processing
PCA	Principal Component Analysis
PRNU	Photo Response Non-Uniformity
ReLU	Rectified Linear Unit
ResNet	Residual Network

RNN	Recurrent Neural Network
UML	Unified Modeling Language
VAE	Variational Autoencoder
ViT	Vision Transformer
WCSS	Within-Cluster Sum of Squares

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

In the modern digital era, the boundaries between physical reality and virtual representation have become increasingly blurred. The exponential growth of data processing capabilities and the sophistication of artificial intelligence have ushered in a new epoch of media consumption, where digital content is no longer a mere reflection of truth but can be a meticulously crafted synthesis [16], [23]. While these innovations drive creativity and progress, they also introduce unprecedented challenges to the integrity of visual information. This chapter establishes the fundamental context of this research, beginning with the evolution of synthetic media and the motivations behind developing robust detection mechanisms, followed by an identification of the current limitations in existing methodologies.

1.1.1 Historical Background and Motivation

The rapid advancement of digital media technologies, combined with the widespread adoption of social networking platforms, has fundamentally transformed how visual information is created, distributed, and consumed. Video content has emerged as a dominant medium for communication, journalism, political discourse, and digital evidence. While these developments offer substantial societal benefits, they have also enabled the rise of a highly disruptive technology known as Deepfake [26].

Deepfakes are synthetically generated or manipulated media in which a person's facial appearance, expressions, or speech are altered using artificial intelligence techniques. Earlier video manipulation methods were limited by high computational costs, technical complexity, and the requirement for expert-level skills. However, recent advances in deep learning—particularly Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) [1], [21] and autoencoder-based architectures [2]—have significantly lowered these barriers. As a result, highly realistic facial manipulations can now be produced with relative ease, making them increasingly difficult for humans to distinguish from authentic videos [12], [19].

This rapid evolution has positioned Deepfake videos as a serious threat to individuals, institutions, and society. They have been used to spread misinformation, manipulate public opinion, commit identity fraud, damage reputations, and bypass biometric security systems [20], [25]. Consequently, automated and reliable Deepfake detection has become a critical research challenge, especially in video-based media where both visual realism and temporal coherence are intentionally optimized to evade detection [24].

The developed Deepfake Detection System has several important real-world applications. Social media platforms and news organizations can use such systems for media verification to automatically detect manipulated videos, reducing the spread of fake news and misleading content. In addition, the detector can be integrated into biometric authentication and security systems to prevent spoofing attacks that attempt to bypass face recognition using deepfake videos. Moreover, courts and law enforcement agencies can employ deepfake detection tools in legal and digital forensics to verify the authenticity of video evidence, supporting fair and accurate legal proceedings [28]. Finally, public figures, journalists, and

private individuals can benefit from automated detection mechanisms that protect identity and reputation by identifying and flagging synthetic media intended to cause reputational harm.

To address this challenge, extensive research has been conducted on deepfake detection. Early studies focused on identifying spatial artifacts in manipulated images, such as inconsistencies in facial texture, lighting, or color distribution [11], [22], with Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) proving particularly effective [15]. Subsequent work extended these methods to video data by applying frame-based detectors sequentially, while more recent approaches have incorporated temporal modeling techniques—including Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) [7], Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks [6], and Transformer-based architectures [5], [17]—to capture abnormal facial motion and frame-to-frame inconsistencies. Benchmark datasets such as Celeb-DF-v2 [13] have further supported evaluation under more realistic and challenging manipulation scenarios.

1.1.2 Research Gap

Despite these advancements, accurately identifying manipulated videos remains an open and challenging problem, and a clear research gap still exists in the current literature [18]. Most existing approaches continue to place primary emphasis on spatial features extracted from individual frames, while the temporal dimension of video data is either weakly modeled or insufficiently utilized. As Deepfake generation techniques continue to advance, manipulated videos increasingly exhibit realistic facial appearances and smooth temporal continuity, rendering spatial artifacts less apparent and reducing the effectiveness of frame-based detection methods [29].

Moreover, many video-based detection systems rely on sparse frame sampling or full-frame analysis. Such strategies risk overlooking subtle manipulation cues that become evident only through continuous temporal observation [9]. In addition, processing full frames often introduces irrelevant background information, which can degrade detection accuracy and generalization performance. These limitations are particularly pronounced when detection models are evaluated on high-quality Deepfake videos or previously unseen manipulation techniques [14], [27].

Therefore, there is a strong need for a robust video-based Deepfake detection framework that explicitly models temporal inconsistencies, adopts a face-centric analysis strategy, and integrates spatial and temporal information in a unified manner. Addressing this research gap is essential for improving the reliability, robustness, and real-world applicability of Deepfake detection systems.

1.2 Problem Statement

Despite notable progress in Deepfake detection research, accurately identifying manipulated videos remains an open and challenging problem. Most existing approaches place primary emphasis on spatial features extracted from individual frames, while the temporal dimension of video data is either weakly modeled or insufficiently utilized. As Deepfake generation techniques continue to advance, manipulated videos increasingly exhibit realistic facial appearances and smooth temporal continuity, rendering spatial artifacts less apparent and reducing the effectiveness of frame-based detection methods [11], [18].

Moreover, many video-based detection systems rely on sparse frame sampling or full-frame analysis. Such strategies risk overlooking subtle manipulation cues that become evident only through continuous temporal observation. In addition, processing full frames often introduces irrelevant background information, which can degrade detection accuracy and generalization performance. These limitations are particularly pronounced when detection models are evaluated on high-quality Deepfake videos or previously unseen manipulation techniques [13], [14].

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1.3 Research Objectives (Numbered Format)

The primary objective of this research is to design and evaluate an effective and robust video-based deepfake detection system that addresses the limitations identified in previous studies. To achieve this goal, the research focuses on the following specific technical objectives:

1. **Construction and Utilization of a Large-Scale Dataset**
To build and utilize a large, diverse, and challenging video dataset based on the **Celeb-DF-v2 benchmark [13]**, incorporating extensive **data augmentation strategies** to mitigate class imbalance, enhance data diversity, and improve model generalization.
2. **Unsupervised Exploration of Nonlinear Data Patterns**
To employ **unsupervised learning techniques** to explore and analyze the nonlinear patterns and intrinsic structures within the dataset, supporting dataset refinement and improving data quality before supervised learning.
3. **Proposal of a Novel Deep Learning Architecture**
To design and evaluate a deep learning framework that effectively integrates powerful **convolutional neural network (CNN) feature extractors [3], [4]** with **sequence-based models**. This hybrid architecture aims to jointly learn discriminative **spatial features** and meaningful **temporal dependencies** that characterize deepfake videos.

4. Improvement of Frame Sampling Precision

To enhance the precision of **frame sampling strategies** by selecting representative and informative frames from video sequences. This objective seeks to reduce temporal redundancy while preserving subtle and critical manipulation cues that may be overlooked by sparse or uniform sampling approaches.

5. Development of an Advanced Preprocessing Pipeline

To propose a robust **face-centric preprocessing pipeline** based on accurate **face detection** and **facial region cropping**. This approach ensures that the detection model focuses exclusively on manipulated facial areas, minimizing the influence of irrelevant background information and improving detection reliability [8].

6. Emphasis on Temporal Effects in Video-Based Deepfake Detection

To explicitly model temporal inconsistencies across consecutive video frames, including unnatural facial motion, abnormal blinking behavior [9], and other temporal artifacts that are commonly overlooked in frame-based detection methods [29].

These objectives collectively aim to improve the accuracy, robustness, and real-world applicability of deepfake detection systems when applied to high-quality and temporally coherent manipulated videos.

1.4 Data Preprocessing and Exploration

Prior to supervised model training, a comprehensive data preprocessing and exploration pipeline was applied to the video dataset. This pipeline consisted of two complementary components: **face-based preprocessing** and **unsupervised clustering-based data exploration**. The objective of this stage was not direct classification, but rather to improve data quality, enhance representativeness, and support informed dataset organization.

First, all video samples were processed using a face-centric approach. Each video was decomposed into individual frames, after which facial regions were detected using a robust face detection framework. Detected faces were cropped based on bounding box coordinates, resized to a fixed spatial resolution, and normalized. Frames with low detection confidence or missing faces were discarded. This step ensured that subsequent analysis and learning focused exclusively on facial regions, where deepfake manipulation artifacts are predominantly localized [10].

In parallel, unsupervised learning techniques were employed for **data exploration and refinement**. High-dimensional feature vectors extracted from preprocessed facial frames were first projected into a lower-dimensional space using **Principal Component Analysis (PCA)**. This dimensionality reduction step preserved the most significant variance while enabling effective visualization and pattern analysis.

Following PCA, **K-Means clustering** was applied to group samples based on feature similarity. The clustering process was not intended to perform real–fake classification. Instead, it served multiple preprocessing objectives:

- (1) identifying overlaps between real and manipulated samples,
- (2) detecting outliers and noisy instances that could degrade supervised learning performance, and
- (3) assessing the inherent separability of the dataset based on extracted facial features.

Insights obtained from this combined preprocessing strategy informed key decisions regarding data cleaning, augmentation, and the **train–validation–test split**. By integrating face-based preprocessing with unsupervised clustering analysis, the overall robustness, consistency, and reliability of the supervised deepfake detection models were significantly enhanced.

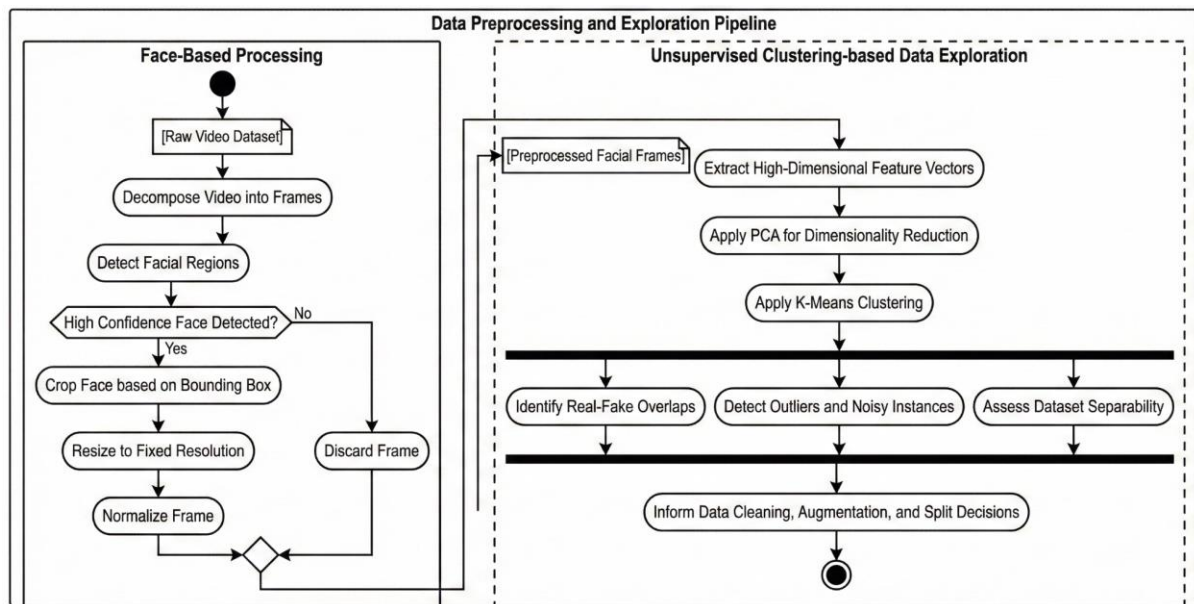


Figure 1.4: UML Activity Diagram - Data Preprocessing and Exploration Pipeline

1.5 Methods of Production (Model Architectures)

The core challenge in deepfake detection lies in the effective integration of spatial and temporal information to distinguish between authentic and manipulated content. To address this, various architectural paradigms have been developed, each leveraging different mechanisms to identify artifacts—ranging from pixel-level irregularities to inconsistent facial dynamics. This research evaluates three distinct hybrid architectures that represent the evolution of sequence modeling in computer vision. By combining robust feature extractors with advanced temporal aggregators, these methods aim to capture the subtle cues that deepfake generation models often fail to replicate accurately. The following sections detail the technical structure and rationale behind each of the implemented models.

1.5.1 CNN + Transformer

In this approach, a Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) is used to extract spatial features from individual video frames. These features capture local textures, edges, and facial structures. The extracted frame-level features are then passed to a Transformer Encoder [5], which models temporal dependencies across the video sequence. The attention mechanism allows the model to focus on frames or regions that exhibit suspicious inconsistencies, making it particularly effective for long-range temporal analysis, similar to approaches proposed in Video Vision Transformers [17].

1.5.2 ResNet-18 + LSTM

This method combines a pre-trained ResNet-18 architecture [4] with a Bidirectional Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) network [6]. ResNet-18 serves as a powerful feature extractor, benefiting from transfer learning on large-scale image datasets. The LSTM processes sequences of frame features and captures temporal dynamics, such as unnatural motion or flickering artifacts, that are characteristic of deepfake videos.

1.5.3 Recurrent Neural Network (RNN)

In this method, a Recurrent Neural Network (RNN) is employed to model temporal dependencies across video frames [7]. After spatial feature extraction using a CNN backbone [3], [30], the sequential features are fed into an RNN architecture designed to learn frame-to-frame correlations over time. Unlike LSTM, standard RNNs have a simpler structure and fewer parameters, which makes them computationally efficient but more sensitive to vanishing gradient issues when processing long sequences. This method was evaluated to compare temporal learning capabilities and to analyze the trade-off between model complexity and performance in deepfake detection tasks.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Chapter Introduction

Synthetic media and deepfakes have evolved from experimental demonstrations into a widespread socio-technical challenge affecting journalism, public trust, cybersecurity, and democratic processes. A deepfake is commonly defined as AI-generated or AI-manipulated audiovisual content that convincingly alters a person’s face, identity, voice, or expressions. The central difficulty in the deepfake problem is the accelerating realism produced by modern generative models, particularly the shift from early autoencoders to advanced Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) and recent Diffusion Probabilistic Models [16]. This rapid evolution makes human inspection and simple forensic checks increasingly unreliable. Consequently, deepfake detection has become an essential research area focused on restoring trust in digital information and reducing the spread of misinformation.

At the same time, a “practical” deepfake detection system must go beyond high benchmark accuracy on static datasets. It should be robust under real-world distortions—such as aggressive compression, resolution changes, lighting variations, and motion blur—and generalize to unseen manipulation methods [17]. Furthermore, systems must provide consistent video-level decisions rather than unstable frame-level guesses. Modern literature therefore increasingly emphasizes end-to-end pipelines that integrate preprocessing (face-centric extraction), feature learning (deep spatial encoders), temporal reasoning (sequence models), and deployment considerations. This chapter reviews the main streams of deepfake generation and detection research, introduces widely used datasets and evaluation protocols, compares state-of-the-art architectures, and highlights the research gaps that motivate the proposed system. The review is organized from foundational background (generation methods and forensic cues) to modern deep neural approaches (CNN/LSTM/Transformer hybrids) and finally to practical issues (pipelines, metrics, and deployment).



Figure 2.1: The subtle difference between real and fake

2.2 Deepfakes and Synthetic Media: Definitions and Evolution

Deepfakes represent a class of synthetic media produced by deep learning techniques that can manipulate or fabricate human identity in images and videos. While early forms of manipulated media relied on manual editing (CGI) which required significant expertise and budget, deepfakes automate identity swaps and facial reenactment using learned representations [18]. As these techniques spread through open-source tools (e.g., DeepFaceLab, Faceswap) and consumer hardware, the barrier to creating convincing forgeries has dramatically decreased.

The evolution of deepfakes is closely connected to progress in generative modeling. Early systems often produced visible artifacts—such as warping, color mismatch, unnatural blending borders, and lack of eye blinking—which could be detected by humans or simple forensic methods [9]. However, modern generators have significantly improved coherence in textures, illumination, and facial dynamics, reducing obvious visual flaws. Recent advancements allow for high-fidelity synthesis at 1024x1024 resolution and above, blending the source and target faces seamlessly even under extreme lighting conditions [19]. This progress increases the difficulty of detection, particularly for short clips or low-resolution videos circulated online. In parallel, the rise of deepfake content has created a wider “trust crisis” in digital media. Even authentic video evidence can be challenged as potentially manipulated, a phenomenon known as the “liar’s dividend” [20]. Therefore, the literature frames deepfake detection not only as a binary classification task but also as a societal defense mechanism that supports media verification, platform moderation, and digital forensics.

2.3 Deepfake Generation Techniques

The efficacy of a detection system is intrinsically linked to its understanding of the underlying generative processes [18]. As synthesis methods evolve from simple image-processing heuristics to sophisticated deep learning frameworks, the artifacts they leave behind become increasingly subtle. This section explores the architectural foundations of contemporary Deepfake generation, categorizing them into three primary technological pillars: Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) [1], Autoencoders [2], and the more recent Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Models [16]. By analyzing how these models manipulate latent representations and reconstruct visual data, we can better identify the structural and statistical anomalies that serve as the “digital fingerprints” for forensic analysis [22].

2.3.1 GAN-Based Generation

Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs), introduced by Goodfellow et al. [1], represent a pivotal moment in synthetic media. GANs operate on a min-max game principle where two neural networks contest with each other: a generator tries to create realistic data instances, and a discriminator acts as a critic to distinguish fake data from real data. This adversarial training leads to continuous improvement, enabling the synthesis of photorealistic faces, expressions, and even full-body motion in advanced systems like StyleGAN [21].

GAN-based deepfakes are particularly challenging for detectors because the generator is explicitly trained to fool a classifier (the discriminator). This allows them to minimize pixel-

level errors and reduce clear blending artifacts. Modern GAN architectures, such as StarGAN or cycle-consistent GANs, can match lighting and skin texture while preserving consistent identity across frames. As GANs improve, detectors can no longer rely on obvious visual glitches and must instead focus on subtler cues, such as frequency domain inconsistencies [12], camera-level artifacts (PRNU), or physiological signals (pulse, gaze) that are hard to synthesize perfectly.

2.3.2 Autoencoders and Variational Autoencoders

Autoencoder-based face swapping is the foundational technology behind the original "Deepfakes" Reddit phenomenon. In this approach, an encoder compresses facial features into a lower-dimensional latent representation, and a decoder reconstructs the face. By training a shared encoder but separate decoders for two different identities (Source A and Target B), the system can swap faces by encoding Face A and decoding it with Decoder B.

Variational Autoencoders (VAEs) [2] improve robustness by enforcing a probabilistic latent distribution (usually Gaussian). This regularization ensures the latent space is continuous, allowing for smoother interpolation between facial expressions. While VAEs yield stable identity transfer and are computationally efficient for editing workflows, they historically suffer from the "blurriness" problem. They often produce outputs that lack high-frequency details (hair strands, skin pores), leaving subtle traces such as texture over-smoothing and imperfect blending boundaries [22]. These specific reconstruction patterns act as fingerprints that detection models can learn to identify.

2.3.3 Diffusion and Modern Video Synthesis

A significant shift in the generative landscape is the emergence of Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Models (DDPMs) and Latent Diffusion Models (LDMs) [16]. Unlike GANs, which generate images in a single pass, diffusion models iteratively denoise a random Gaussian noise signal to reconstruct a high-fidelity image conditioned on text or image inputs. These methods have demonstrated superior capability in handling complex backgrounds, lighting interactions, and semantic coherence compared to GANs [23].

While diffusion is famous for text-to-image generation (e.g., DALL-E, Stable Diffusion), it is increasingly applied to video synthesis and face swapping. The trend toward temporally coherent generation is especially important: many earlier detectors relied on temporal flickering or unstable frame-to-frame artifacts. Modern video diffusion models incorporate temporal attention layers to ensure that the generated subject maintains consistent identity and motion physics over time. Consequently, detection research has had to shift toward models capable of capturing semantic inconsistencies (e.g., logical errors in the scene) and long-range dependencies, as low-level signal artifacts become less prominent [24].

Table 2.1: Characteristics and Forensic Trace Patterns of Deepfake Generation Techniques.

Generation Technique	Primary Strength	Common Detection Artifact
GANs	High photorealism	Frequency domain inconsistencies
Autoencoders	Identity preservation	Texture smoothing & blending edges
Diffusion	Temporal & semantic coherence	Logical scene errors & semantic anomalies

2.4 Threat Landscape: Deepfakes, Misinformation, and Social Harm

Deepfakes are frequently discussed in the literature as a mechanism for misinformation amplification, reputation attacks, identity fraud, and political manipulation. Their power lies in leveraging human trust in visual evidence; the psychological impact of seeing a person say something is far stronger than reading a fabricated quote. A realistic deepfake can influence beliefs rapidly, especially when shared widely on social media platforms, where verification is difficult and emotional reactions spread faster than fact-checking [25].

Beyond political misinformation, deepfakes pose tangible security threats. They are increasingly used for cybercrime, such as "CEO fraud" where synthetic audio or video is used to trick employees into transferring funds [26]. In biometric security, deepfakes can bypass facial recognition systems (Presentation Attacks). In legal contexts, the existence of deepfakes complicates evidentiary trust; the "alibi of the machine" allows bad actors to dismiss authentic incriminating footage as fake. Therefore, detection systems must be robust, scalable, and deployable in real-world workflows, capable of flagging manipulated content with high confidence to support human moderators.

2.5 Datasets and Benchmarks for Deepfake Detection

Deepfake detection research depends on publicly available datasets that provide labeled real and manipulated content. These datasets enable training and benchmarking but also introduce challenges regarding domain shift.

FaceForensics++ [8]: Remains the standard benchmark for comparing detection architectures. It provides 1,000 original videos manipulated by four methods (Deepfakes, Face2Face, FaceSwap, NeuralTextures) at three compression levels (Raw, C23, C40). While excellent for baseline comparisons, its controlled nature implies that models trained solely here often fail on "wild" deepfakes.

Celeb-DF (v2) [13]: Was created to address the low visual quality of early datasets. It contains 5,639 high-quality videos where artifacts like color mismatch and temporal flickering are minimized. High performance on Celeb-DF usually indicates better generalization to realistic forgeries.

DFDC (DeepFake Detection Challenge) [14]: A large-scale dataset featuring over 100,000 clips with diverse lighting, backgrounds, and paid actors. It represents the "wild" environment of social media. The low top-tier accuracy on DFDC during the Kaggle competition highlighted the difficulty of detecting deepfakes in uncontrolled environments.

WildDeepfake [27]: A dataset collected entirely from the internet, representing real-world forgeries rather than lab-generated ones. It is crucial for testing cross-dataset generalization.

The literature increasingly calls for cross-dataset evaluation (training on dataset A, testing on dataset B) as the true measure of a detector's utility [28].

2.6 Classical Forensic and Signal-Based Detection Approaches

Before deep learning dominated deepfake detection, classical forensics focused on handcrafted features and signal artifacts. These methods operate on the premise that the generation process leaves specific traces in the image signal.

Techniques analyzed image statistics, compression signatures (JPEG blocking), noise residuals, chromatic aberration, and frequency domain patterns. Biological signals have also been a rich source of forensic cues; for instance, Li et al. [9] detected deepfakes by analyzing eye-blinking frequencies, while others analyzed the synchronization between lip movements and speech [29]. Another approach involves checking for inconsistent head poses or lighting directions between the face and the background.

The primary advantage of classical forensics is interpretability—an expert can explain why an image is fake (e.g., "inconsistent shadows"). However, these approaches are often brittle; they fail when generators improve (e.g., GANs now incorporate blinking) or when media is re-encoded by social platforms, which destroys subtle signal traces. Practical systems now often use these as complementary features alongside deep learning.

2.7 Deep Learning Detection Approaches: Spatial Models

The initial defense against synthetic media relies on the extraction of high-dimensional spatial features that define the visual integrity of an image. Spatial models operate under the premise that even the most advanced generative frameworks leave subtle "forgery fingerprints" at the pixel level—whether in the form of texture anomalies or structural inconsistencies. These approaches leverage the hierarchical nature of deep neural networks to identify local and global artifacts within individual frames [28]. This section categorizes spatial detection into two primary methodologies: standard frame-level classification and the more specialized frequency-aware analysis.

2.7.1 CNN-Based Frame-Level Detection

Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) are foundational in deepfake detection because they automatically learn discriminative features from pixel patterns. Frame-level detectors treat video fraud detection as a standard image classification problem. Architectures such as XceptionNet [3], ResNet [4], and EfficientNet [30] are commonly used backbones. These models look for spatial artifacts: unnatural skin texture, resolution mismatches between face and background, and edge blending ghosts. While frame-level CNNs are fast and effective on uncompressed data, they suffer from two major limitations:

- **Lack of Temporal Reasoning:** They cannot detect inconsistencies that only appear over time (e.g., a face that flickers or moves unnaturally).
- **Overfitting to Artifacts:** They tend to memorize specific artifacts of the training set (e.g., a specific compression pattern of FaceForensics++ [8]) rather than learning semantic forgery cues, leading to poor cross-dataset performance [12].

2.7.2 Frequency and Artifact-Aware CNNs

To improve robustness against compression, researchers have looked beyond the RGB domain. Generative models often exhibit distinct fingerprints in the frequency domain due to up-sampling operations, which often manifest as checkerboard artifacts. Frequency-aware detectors utilize Discrete Cosine Transforms (DCT) or Fourier Transforms to analyze spectral distributions.

Recent works have proposed multi-stream networks that process RGB and Frequency data in parallel [22]. This allows the network to spot high-frequency noise anomalies that are invisible to the human eye. While these methods improve robustness, they can still degrade when aggressive social media compression removes the high-frequency information where these artifacts reside [24].

2.8 Temporal Deepfake Detection: Sequence Modeling

While spatial models focus on static irregularities, the essence of video lies in its temporal continuity. Temporal detection paradigms shift the focus from "what the face looks like" to "how the face moves." This approach is essential because modern generative techniques, while capable of producing high-fidelity static images, often struggle to maintain physiological and physical consistency across a sequence of frames [9]. By treating video as a temporal signal

rather than a collection of independent images, sequence modeling can identify subtle flickering and motion artifacts that remain invisible to frame-level detectors. The following sections discuss the evolution of recurrent architectures in capturing these dynamic inconsistencies.

2.8.1 RNN and LSTM-Based Video Detection

Temporal modeling addresses the dynamic nature of video. A deepfake might look perfect in a single frame, but the sequence of frames might reveal jittery movements or inconsistent expressions. Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) and their advanced variant, Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) [6], are designed to handle such sequential data.

In a typical pipeline, a CNN extracts a feature vector from each frame, and an LSTM processes these vectors to classify the sequence. This allows the system to capture "temporal flickering" and behavioral irregularities. However, standard LSTMs suffer from the vanishing gradient problem in very long sequences and process data strictly sequentially, which prevents them from comparing the start and end of a video efficiently [7].

2.8.2 Bidirectional LSTM (Bi-LSTM)

To overcome the limitations of unidirectional processing, Bidirectional LSTMs (Bi-LSTM) process the video sequence in both directions (past-to-future and future-to-past). This is crucial for deepfake detection because evidence of manipulation might be distributed anywhere in the clip. By seeing the "future" context, the model can better judge if a current frame fits the trajectory of facial motion. Bi-LSTMs provide a richer, more stable temporal representation, significantly improving video-level accuracy compared to frame-based voting methods.

2.9 Transformer-Based Deepfake Detection

Transformers, originally introduced for NLP [5], have revolutionized computer vision through Vision Transformers (ViT). Their core mechanism, Self-Attention, enables the model to weigh the importance of different frames (temporal attention) or different patches within a frame (spatial attention) dynamically.

In deepfake detection, Video Transformers can capture long-range dependencies that LSTMs miss. For example, a Transformer can detect if a person's identity slightly shifts between the first second and the tenth second of a video. Models like the Video Vision Transformer (ViViT) have shown state-of-the-art results by learning complex spatial-temporal interactions [17]. Although Transformers are computationally heavier and require more training data than CNNs, their ability to model global context makes them highly robust against advanced deepfakes that have perfect local texture but semantic flaws.

2.10 Hybrid Architectures: Spatial–Temporal Fusion

A major trend in the literature is hybrid modeling, combining the feature extraction power of CNNs with the temporal reasoning of Sequence Models. The consensus is that neither spatial

nor temporal cues are sufficient alone. A hybrid detector typically consists of: Front-end: A CNN (e.g., EfficientNet or Xception) to extract spatial embeddings. Middle-end: A temporal module (Bi-LSTM or Transformer) to model vector evolution.

This fusion aligns with the nature of the threat: deepfakes contain both static artifacts (blending errors) and dynamic artifacts (jitter). Hybrid designs also allow for modular optimization; for instance, a lightweight CNN + Bi-LSTM can be deployed for real-time screening, while a heavy CNN + Transformer is reserved for high-stakes forensic analysis.

2.11 Preprocessing Pipelines and Practical Considerations

The transition from theoretical model design to practical deployment requires a robust preprocessing infrastructure. In the context of Deepfake forensics, the "garbage in, garbage out" principle is particularly relevant; even the most sophisticated temporal models can fail if the input data is poorly centered or contains excessive environmental noise. Effective preprocessing serves to isolate the region of interest and standardize the input format, thereby allowing the network to focus exclusively on forensic anomalies rather than background variations. This section details the critical stages of facial alignment and sampling strategies that ensure both computational efficiency and detection accuracy.

2.11.1 Face-Centric Preprocessing

Deepfake detection is almost exclusively a face-centric task. Therefore, the performance of the detector is heavily dependent on the quality of the preprocessing pipeline. This typically involves:

1. **Face Detection:** Using MTCNN or RetinaFace to locate the face.
2. **Landmark Alignment:** Rotating and scaling the face so eyes and mouth align to standard coordinates.
3. **Cropping:** Removing the background to reduce noise.

Research shows that including a margin around the face (capturing part of the background) can actually help detection, as it reveals blending boundaries [11].

2.11.2 Frame Sampling Strategies

Processing every frame in a video is computationally prohibitive. Frame sampling strategies are thus critical for deployment. Sparse sampling (taking 1 frame every second) is efficient but risks missing brief glitches. Clip-based sampling (taking short continuous chunks) is better for temporal models. Recent research suggests **Key-frame extraction**, where the system selects frames with high motion or potential artifacts, rather than random sampling, to maximize detection probability [18].

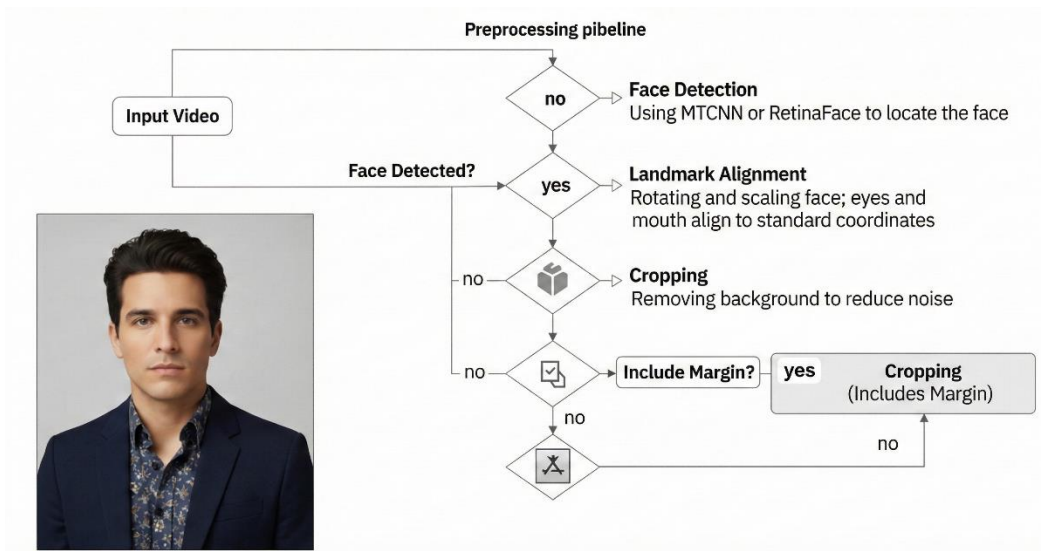


Figure 2.2.: Face Detection and Alignment Workflow

2.12 Evaluation Metrics and Real-World Deployment

Deepfake detectors are evaluated using standard metrics: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-score, and AUC (Area Under Curve). In security contexts, the False Positive Rate (FPR) is critical; a system that frequently flags authentic videos as fake will be rejected by users.

Deployment introduces challenges often ignored in academic papers: Robustness to re-encoding: Videos on WhatsApp or Facebook are heavily compressed. Adversarial Attackers can add imperceptible noise to a deepfake to fool the detector [24]. Users need to know why a video is flagged (e.g., "Lip movements do not match audio"). Practical systems, therefore, are moving towards "Forensics-as-a-Service," providing confidence scores and heatmaps rather than simple binary labels.

2.13 Summary and Research Gaps

The literature shows a clear shift from handcrafted forensic features to deep neural detectors and then toward hybrid and attention-based video models. While CNN-based methods remain important for feature extraction, their limitations under high-quality deepfakes and domain shift have motivated the adoption of temporal modeling with Bi-LSTMs and Transformers. However, significant research gaps remain: Generalization: Most systems still struggle when tested on datasets they were not trained on (the Cross-Dataset problem). Adversarial Robustness: Few detectors are tested against anti-forensic attacks. Multimodal Integration: While audio-visual cues are promising, they are under-explored compared to pure video analysis.

The proposed system is positioned to address these gaps specifically by implementing a robust spatial-temporal hybrid architecture that prioritizes generalization and deployment feasibility.

CHAPTER THREE

METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter presents a comprehensive methodological framework designed to address the challenge of detecting high-fidelity deepfake videos. The proposed system is a Hybrid Spatiotemporal Deep Learning Framework whose core is a ResNet-18 convolutional backbone coupled with an encoder-only Transformer (a stack of multi-head self-attention layers operating on the sequence of frame embeddings). Unlike traditional approaches that rely on single-frame analysis, this research posits that the most discriminative artifacts in modern deepfakes—such as micro-expression inconsistencies and lip-sync drifts—are inherently temporal, and that the global self-attention mechanism of the Transformer is the most suitable paradigm for capturing them.

The methodology is implemented through a systematic pipeline consisting of four distinct phases:

1. **Data Acquisition and Preprocessing:** Utilization of the Celeb-DF-v2 dataset with a face-centric preprocessing pipeline.
2. **Unsupervised Data Analysis:** Application of Principal Component Analysis (PCA) and K-Means clustering to explore data separability prior to supervised training.
3. **Model Architecture Design:** Implementation of the proposed Hybrid CNN + Transformer Encoder architecture, benchmarked against two comparative models (ResNet + Bi-LSTM and a baseline RNN).
4. **Training and Evaluation:** A rigorous training regimen using specific hyperparameters, loss functions, and evaluation metrics.

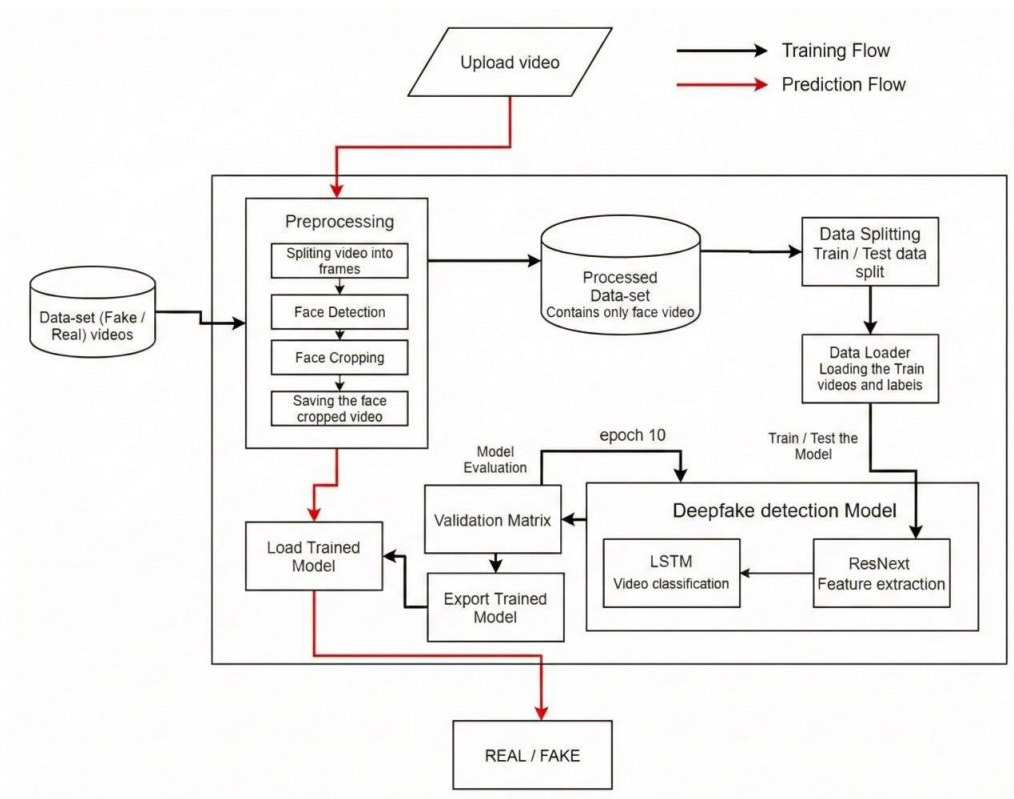


Figure 3.1: System Architecture

3.2 Dataset Preparation and Preprocessing Pipeline

The integrity of a deep learning model is fundamentally rooted in the quality and diversity of the data used for its training and evaluation. In the domain of deepfake forensics, the shift toward more sophisticated generation techniques necessitates the use of benchmark datasets that mirror the complexities of real-world digital media [13]. This section details the selection of the Celeb-DF-v2 dataset, its composition and class distribution, the rigorous cleaning and partitioning protocols implemented to ensure unbiased evaluation, the augmentation strategies employed to enhance generalization, the face-centric preprocessing methodology applied to all video samples, the unsupervised exploratory analysis conducted prior to supervised training, and the experimental configuration adopted to ensure reproducibility across all evaluated architectures.

3.2.1 Dataset Description and Distribution

Celeb-DF-v2 is chosen over earlier datasets such as FaceForensics++ [8] because it addresses the visual quality gap that renders earlier benchmarks insufficiently challenging for modern detection systems. Early datasets contained obvious visual artifacts including ghosting and color mismatch that are easily detected by simple classifiers, whereas Celeb-DF-v2 contains 5,639 videos characterized by reduced temporal flickering, improved color blending, diverse lighting conditions, varying head poses, and background clutter. Real videos are sourced from YouTube interviews of 59 celebrities, providing a challenging real-world distribution that closely approximates unconstrained deployment scenarios. The dataset was carefully partitioned into training, validation, and testing subsets using an 80:10:10 ratio performed strictly at the video level — not the frame level — to prevent data leakage and ensure that frames from the same source video do not appear across multiple splits. Table 3.1 presents the detailed distribution of the test subset used for final performance evaluation.

Table 3.1: Test Dataset Distribution

Class	Description	Number of Samples	Percentage
Fake	Manipulated videos (Deepfakes)	1,130	53.6%
Real	Authentic videos (Originals)	978	46.4%
Total	Complete Test Set	2,108	100.0%

The slight imbalance toward fake samples (53.6%) simulates practical deployment scenarios where detection systems must handle varying proportions of manipulated content, ensuring that reported performance metrics accurately reflect real-world applicability rather than artificially balanced conditions.

3.2.2 Data Cleaning and Augmentation

Prior to processing, corrupted video files were filtered out to eliminate samples that could introduce inconsistent gradients during training. To improve generalization and prevent overfitting, the following augmentation techniques were applied dynamically during training: random horizontal flipping with a probability of 0.5; color jitter consisting of slight random adjustments to brightness, contrast, and saturation to simulate variations across camera sensors; and small-angle random rotations to handle head pose variations present across the diverse celebrity source material.

3.2.3 Face-Centric Preprocessing Methodology

The efficacy of deep learning models in facial forensics is highly contingent upon the precision and consistency of the input data. A robust preprocessing pipeline is therefore essential to isolate biometric facial features from environmental noise, illumination variations, and compression artifacts, ensuring that the neural network converges on forgery-specific inconsistencies rather than irrelevant background information. The pipeline consisted of three primary sequential stages, as illustrated in Figure 3.2.

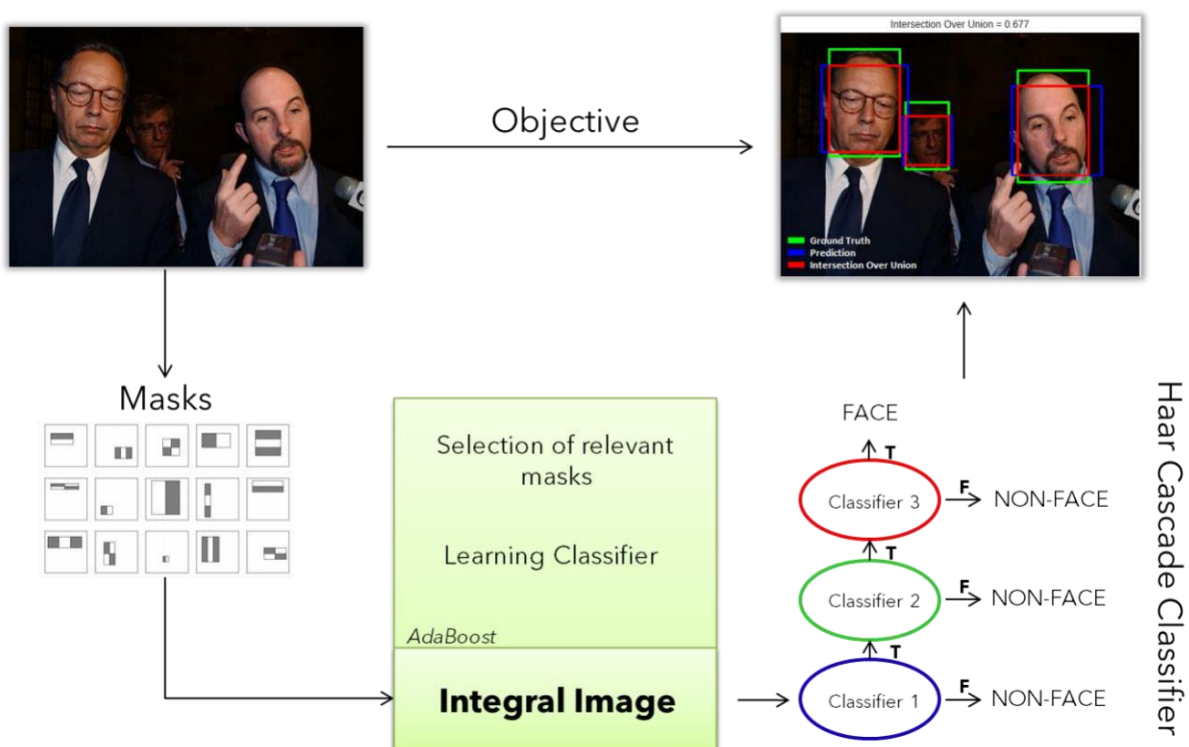


Figure 3.2: Overview of the Face-Centric Preprocessing Methodology

Stage 1 — Face Detection and Extraction:

Each video sequence is first temporally decomposed to extract a sequence of frames

$$\mathbf{F} = \{\mathbf{f}_1, \mathbf{f}_2, \dots, \mathbf{f}_T\}.$$

A Multi-task Cascaded Convolutional Network (MTCNN) or RetinaFace detector is then employed to localize facial bounding boxes in each frame. To preserve boundary artifacts introduced during face blending, a margin is added to the detected bounding box using a scale factor $\alpha > 1.0$, a step that is critical since deepfake artifacts are often most pronounced at the interface between the synthesized face and the background. Frames with low detection confidence or missing faces are discarded, and failed detections are handled through interpolation from adjacent frames to maintain temporal sequence continuity.

Stage 2 — Standardization and Normalization:

All cropped facial regions are resized to a fixed resolution of 224×224 pixels to ensure compatibility with the ResNet-18 backbone pretrained on ImageNet. Pixel intensities are normalized using the ImageNet mean μ and standard deviation σ according to the formula $z = (x - \mu) / \sigma$, following the standard preprocessing protocol for CNN models pretrained on ImageNet and ensuring full compatibility with transfer learning architectures. Color space consistency is enforced across all samples to eliminate sensor-induced variations unrelated to manipulation artifacts.

Stage 3 — Temporal Frame Selection:

Sequential frames are extracted at fixed intervals to capture temporal dynamics while managing computational cost. Frame sequences are padded or truncated to maintain a uniform temporal length across all video samples, ensuring consistent input dimensionality for the temporal modeling modules downstream.

3.2.4 Unsupervised Data Analysis

Before supervised training, an exploratory analysis was conducted to examine the intrinsic structure of the feature space and assess the degree of separability between authentic and manipulated samples.

3.2.4.1 Dimensionality Reduction (PCA)

To visualize high-dimensional feature embeddings, Principal Component Analysis (PCA) was applied to project the data onto a lower-dimensional subspace such that the maximum variance is preserved along the first principal axis. Given a data matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times d}$ of centered feature vectors, the covariance matrix Σ is computed as:

$$\Sigma = 1/(n-1) \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbf{x}_i \mathbf{x}_i^T$$

The principal components correspond to the eigenvectors $\mathbf{v}$ satisfying $\Sigma \mathbf{v} = \lambda \mathbf{v}$, where λ denotes the eigenvalue representing the magnitude of variance along the associated eigenvector. This dimensionality reduction enabled a 2D visualization of the overlap between the Real and Fake classes, revealing the degree of separability before supervised classification, as illustrated in Figure 3.3.

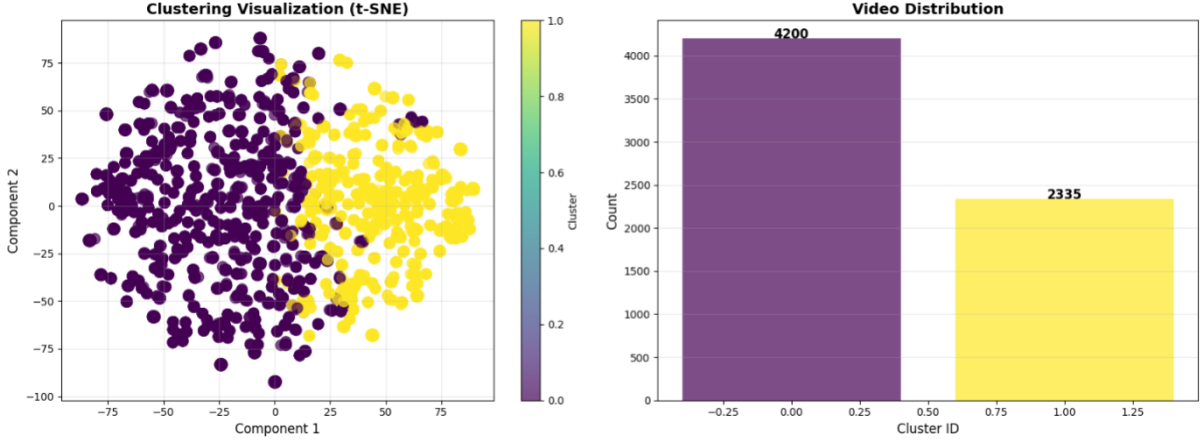


Figure 3.3: Exploratory Data Analysis using PCA and Data Distribution

3.2.4.2 K-Means Clustering

K-Means clustering was employed to analyze data groupings and identify outliers by partitioning n observations into k clusters through minimization of the within-cluster sum of squares (WCSS):

$$J = \sum_{j=1}^k \sum_{i \in S_j} \|x_i - \mu_j\|^2$$

where μ_j denotes the centroid of cluster S_j . This unsupervised step facilitated the identification of hard samples — namely, real videos that appear manipulated due to heavy compression or motion blur, and fake videos that are exceptionally realistic. The analysis revealed substantial overlap between the two classes in the low-dimensional projection, indicating that manipulation artifacts in Celeb-DF-v2 are subtle and cannot be resolved through linear separation alone. Such hard samples are particularly informative during supervised training, as they encourage the model to learn more discriminative and robust representations, and this finding directly reinforces the necessity of the proposed spatiotemporal deep learning framework.

3.3 Experimental Configuration

To ensure reproducibility and enable fair comparison across the three evaluated architectures, a standardized experimental protocol was established prior to model training. All models were trained under identical conditions, with hyperparameters selected through preliminary grid search optimization. Table 3.2 summarizes the complete training configuration adopted throughout all experiments.

Table 3.2: Training Configuration and Hyperparameters

Parameter	Value	Rationale
Deep Learning Framework	PyTorch 1.x	Industry-standard library with efficient GPU support
Optimizer	AdamW	Adaptive learning rate with decoupled weight decay
Initial Learning Rate	0.0008	Empirically determined for stable convergence
Batch Size	8	Memory-optimized for GPU constraints (NVIDIA RTX)
Weight Decay	0.0001	L2 regularization to prevent overfitting
Training Epochs	12	Sufficient for convergence with early stopping
Early Stopping Patience	6 epochs	Monitors validation loss to prevent overfitting
Loss Function	Binary Cross-Entropy	Standard for binary classification tasks
Learning Rate Scheduler	ReduceLROnPlateau	Reduces LR when validation loss plateaus

The selection of the AdamW optimizer over standard Adam provides superior generalization performance through proper decoupled weight decay implementation, which independently penalizes large weights without interfering with the adaptive gradient updates. The Binary Cross-Entropy loss function serves as the standard optimization objective for binary classification, effectively penalizing incorrect high-confidence predictions and guiding the model toward well-calibrated probability outputs. Early stopping with a patience of 6 epochs ensures that training terminates at the point of optimal validation performance, preventing overfitting while maximizing the utilization of available model capacity. The learning rate scheduler further stabilizes convergence by reducing the learning rate upon detecting plateaus in validation loss, enabling finer weight adjustments during the later stages of training.

3.4 The Proposed Architectures

To effectively capture both spatial artifacts and temporal inconsistencies inherent in high-fidelity deepfake videos, this research proposes a hybrid architecture centered on a temporal Transformer Encoder, evaluated against two comparative deep learning architectures. All three architectures share a common spatial backbone while differing in their temporal modeling strategies, enabling a controlled comparison that isolates the contribution of the Transformer’s global self-attention mechanism in spatiotemporal reasoning.

The primary objective of this architectural exploration is to determine the most suitable paradigm for modeling subtle temporal anomalies—such as micro-expression inconsistencies, lip-sync drift, and irregular eye blinking patterns—that are characteristic of modern deepfake manipulations.

3.4.1 Spatial Feature Extraction (Backbone)

In all evaluated configurations, ResNet-18 is utilized as the foundational spatial backbone architecture. The selection of ResNet-18 is primarily driven by its optimal balance between computational efficiency and robust feature extraction capabilities. Furthermore, it inherently mitigates the vanishing gradient problem—a common challenge when training deep neural networks—through the implementation of residual skip connections.

The core operation within a residual block is mathematically defined as:

$$y = \sigma(\mathcal{F}(x, \{W_i\}) + x)$$

where:

1. x represents the identity input to the block.
2. $\mathcal{F}(x, \{W_i\})$ denotes the residual mapping to be learned, which is parameterized by the weight matrices W_i .
3. σ indicates the Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU) activation function applied after the element-wise addition.

During the feature extraction phase, each video frame, denoted as I_t , is passed through the spatial backbone. The network processes the frame to compute and output a dense, fixed-length feature vector (embedding), defined as:

$$f_t = \text{ResNet18}(I_t)$$

where f_t represents the spatial feature representation of the frame at the time step t . Finally, these independent, per-frame spatial embeddings are sequentially forwarded to the temporal modeling modules to capture the inter-frame dynamics and sequential inconsistencies indicative of deepfake manipulations.

3.4.2 Temporal Modeling

While spatial feature extraction captures frame-level visual artifacts, deepfake detection fundamentally requires modeling the temporal coherence and dynamics of facial movements across consecutive frames. Subtle inconsistencies such as irregular blinking patterns, lip-sync drift, and micro-expression anomalies are inherently temporal phenomena that cannot be reliably detected through static analysis alone.

To address this challenge, the proposed framework explores multiple temporal modeling strategies that operate on sequences of frame-level feature embeddings. Each strategy is designed to capture temporal dependencies at a different level of contextual awareness, ranging from global self-attention mechanisms to recurrent memory-based architectures. This architectural diversity enables a principled comparison of how various temporal reasoning paradigms influence the model’s ability to detect high-fidelity deepfake manipulations.

Three temporal modeling strategies were explored to process the sequence of feature vectors:

$$V = \{v_1, v_2, \dots, v_T\}.$$

Each temporal module processes this sequence to learn a discriminative spatiotemporal representation that encodes both short-term motion dynamics and long-range temporal dependencies.

3.4.2.1 CNN + Transformer Encoder (Proposed Architecture — Global Context Modeling)

This configuration constitutes the proposed architecture of this research. To effectively model long-range temporal dependencies, an encoder-only Transformer—the encoder stack of the standard Transformer introduced by Vaswani et al. [17]—is integrated on top of the ResNet-18 backbone. The temporal Transformer Encoder consists of stacked layers, each comprising a multi-head self-attention sub-layer followed by a position-wise feed-forward network, with residual connections and layer normalization. Since self-attention is permutation-invariant, learnable positional encodings are added to the frame embeddings to preserve their temporal order. In contrast to traditional recurrent neural networks (RNNs) that process data sequentially, the Transformer allows each frame to attend to all other frames simultaneously, thereby facilitating comprehensive global contextual reasoning across the entire video sequence. Specifically, the model employs the Scaled Dot-Product Attention mechanism, which is mathematically defined as:

$$\text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{QK^T}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right)V$$

where Q , K , and V represent the query, key, and value matrices, respectively, which are derived from linear projections of the input feature sequence. The term d_k denotes the dimensionality of the key vectors, used as a scaling factor to stabilize gradients during training. Ultimately, this mechanism significantly enhances the model’s analytical capability, enabling it to focus on subtle temporal inconsistencies—such as incongruent blinking patterns or asynchronous lip movements—and to seamlessly capture complex inter-frame relationships regardless of their temporal distance within the sequence.

3.4.2.2 ResNet-18 + Bi-Directional LSTM (Spatial–Temporal Modeling)

This architecture integrates a ResNet-18 spatial backbone with a Bi-directional Long Short-Term Memory (Bi-LSTM) network. The core LSTM gating mechanisms, which regulate the flow of temporal information, are defined mathematically as follows:

$$i_t = \sigma(W_i x_t + U_i h_{t-1} + b_i)$$

$$f_t = \sigma(W_f x_t + U_f h_{t-1} + b_f)$$

$$\begin{aligned}
o_t &= \sigma(W_o x_t + U_o h_{t-1} + b_o) \\
c_t &= f_t \odot c_{t-1} + i_t \odot \tanh(W_c x_t + U_c h_{t-1} + b_c) \\
h_t &= o_t \odot \tanh(c_t)
\end{aligned}$$

where i_t , f_t , and o_t denote the input, forget, and output gates, respectively. The variable c_t represents the cell state, and h_t represents the hidden state.

To comprehensively capture temporal dependencies, the Bi-directional representation is defined as:

$$H_t = \vec{h}_t \oplus \overleftarrow{h}_t$$

where $\vec{h}_t$ and $\overleftarrow{h}_t$ represent the forward and backward hidden states, and the operator $\oplus$ denotes vector concatenation. Ultimately, this formulation significantly enhances the architecture's analytical capabilities by enabling:

1. The seamless incorporation of both past and future contextual cues.
2. Enhanced, robust modeling of complex temporal dynamics throughout the sequence.

3.4.2.3 CNN + RNN (Baseline Architecture)

To establish a comparative performance baseline, a standard Recurrent Neural Network (RNN) is implemented. The core sequential mechanism of this baseline model relies on a simple hidden state update, which is mathematically formulated as:

$$h_t = \tanh(W_h x_t + U_h h_{t-1} + b_h)$$

where x_t represents the input sequence at time step t , h_{t-1} denotes the hidden state from the previous time step, W_h and U_h are the learned weight matrices, and b_h is the bias vector. Unlike more sophisticated architectures, this standard RNN lacks explicit gating mechanisms to regulate the flow of long-term temporal information. Consequently, while the model is highly efficient and computationally lightweight, it is susceptible to vanishing gradients over extended sequences. In the context of this study, it primarily serves as a lower-bound benchmark, providing a rigorous foundation for evaluating and quantifying the performance advantages of integrating advanced temporal modeling techniques.

3.5 Training Strategy

This section provides a comprehensive overview of the training strategy employed to optimize the model's performance and ensure robust generalization capabilities. To achieve this, the training framework was structured around three key pillars: First, the Loss Function and Optimization mechanisms, which define essential hyperparameters such as the learning rate and batch size to facilitate stable convergence. Second, a two-phase Transfer Learning Strategy is designed to maximize the utility of pre-trained feature representations while preventing weight distortion. Finally, Regularization and Early Stopping techniques were carefully integrated to mitigate overfitting and guarantee that the training process concludes at the point of optimal performance.

3.5.1 Loss Function & Optimization

Following the architectural design of the model, the next crucial phase is training the neural network to learn the optimal weights required to accurately and reliably distinguish between authentic and manipulated data. This section outlines the strategy employed to optimize the model's performance. It details the loss function utilized to evaluate predictive accuracy, the chosen optimization algorithm, and the essential hyperparameters governing the training process. The configurations described below were carefully selected to ensure stable and efficient model convergence while minimizing the error in the binary classification task.

1. **Loss Function:** The network was optimized using the **Binary Cross-Entropy (BCE)** loss. BCE is the standard metric for binary classification tasks, as it effectively measures the disparity between the model's predicted probabilities and the actual binary ground-truth labels. It penalizes incorrect, highly confident predictions, guiding the model toward accurate probability distributions. The BCE loss is defined as:

$$L(y, \hat{y}) = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N [y_i \log(\hat{y}_i) + (1 - y_i) \log(1 - \hat{y}_i)]$$

2. **Optimizer:** The **AdamW** (Adam with decoupled Weight decay) optimizer was employed, consistent with the configuration in Table 3.2. AdamW calculates adaptive learning rates for individual parameters based on first and second moments of the gradients while applying weight decay independently of the gradient update, which leads to faster, more stable convergence and superior generalization compared to traditional stochastic gradient descent and standard Adam.
3. **Learning Rate:** The learning rate was set to **0.0008**. This relatively small value was chosen to ensure stable, smooth convergence and to prevent the optimizer from taking steps that are too large, which could lead to overshooting the optimal weights.
4. **Batch Size:** Training was conducted with a batch size of **8 sequences**. Using a smaller batch size helps manage GPU memory constraints (particularly with sequence models) and introduces a degree of noise into the gradient estimates, which can act as an inherent regularizer to help the model escape local minima.
5. **Epochs:** The maximum duration for training was set to **12 epochs**, meaning the model iterates over the entire training dataset a maximum of 12 times.

3.5.2 Transfer Learning Strategy

To leverage pre-existing feature representations and accelerate the model's ability to learn, a two-phase transfer learning approach was implemented:

1. **Phase 1 (Epochs 1-4):** The model's feature-extracting **backbone was frozen**. During these initial epochs, only the newly initialized, task-specific classification head was trained. This prevents the large, unstable gradients from the untrained head from corrupting the valuable pre-trained weights of the backbone.

2. **Phase 2 (Epoch 5 onwards):** At epoch 5, the **backbone was unfrozen**, initiating the fine-tuning phase. The entire network was trained jointly, allowing the pre-trained features to adapt and specialize to the specific nuances of the target dataset.

3.5.3 Regularization & Early Stopping

To ensure the model generalizes effectively to unseen data and avoids memorizing the training set (overfitting), the following strategies were implemented:

1. **Weight Decay:** An L2 regularization (weight decay) factor of **0.0001** was applied within the optimizer. This adds a penalty for excessively large network weights, encouraging a simpler and more generalized model.
2. **Dropout:** Dropout layers were integrated into the architecture to randomly deactivate a percentage of neurons during each forward pass. This forces the network to learn robust, distributed representations and prevents co-adaptation among neurons.
3. **Early Stopping:** An early stopping mechanism was configured to monitor the validation loss at the end of every epoch. A **patience of 6** was utilized, meaning training would automatically halt if the validation loss failed to improve for 6 consecutive epochs. This guarantees the training process stops at the point of optimal generalization, saving computational resources and preventing overtraining.

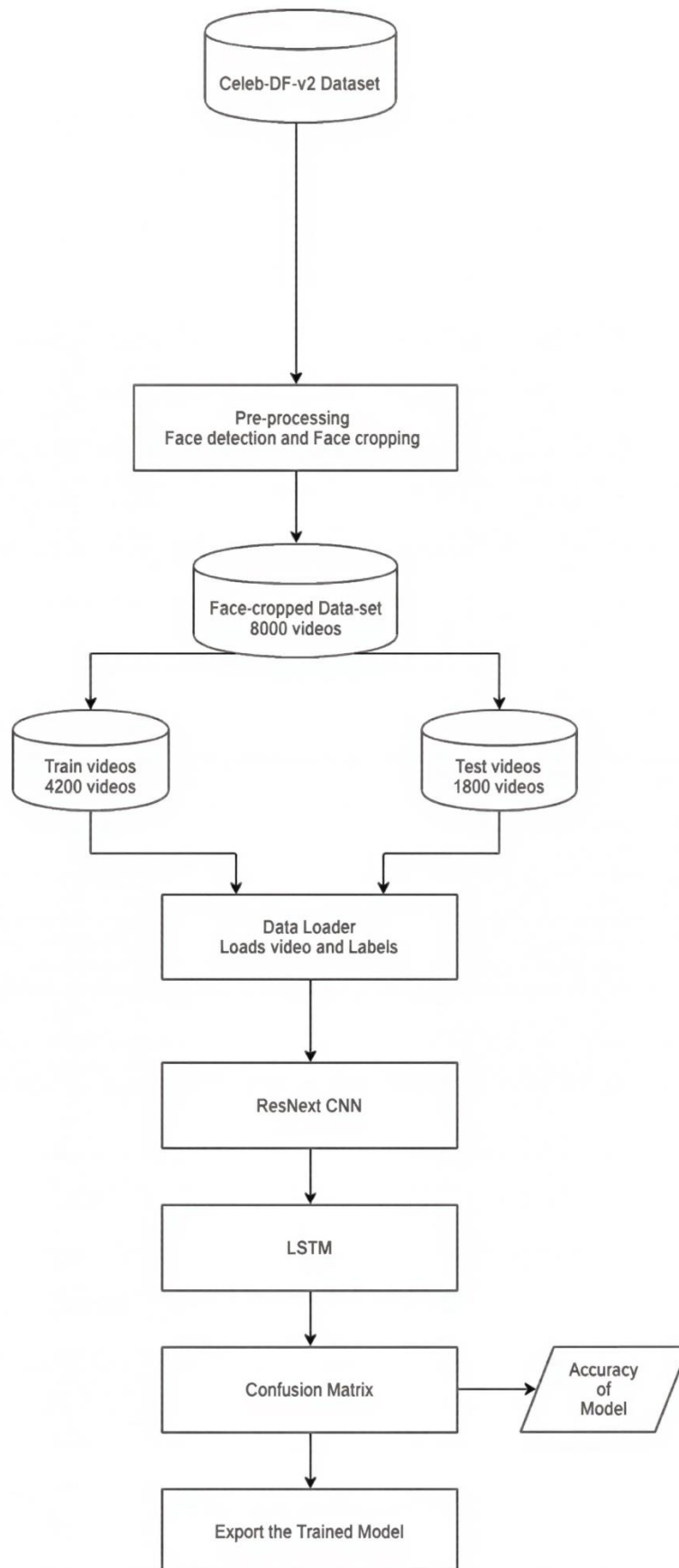


Figure 3.4: Training Workflow

3.6 Summary

This chapter presented the detailed methodology for the proposed deepfake detection system, whose core is a ResNet-18 backbone coupled with an encoder-only temporal Transformer. By integrating a face-centric preprocessing pipeline with unsupervised analysis and benchmarking the proposed Transformer-based model against two comparative temporal architectures (Bi-LSTM and a baseline RNN), the framework captures both the spatial artifacts and the temporal irregularities inherent in synthetic media. The training strategy, incorporating both transfer learning and fine-tuning phases, was carefully designed to maximize the model's generalization capabilities on the highly challenging Celeb-DF-v2 dataset. The detailed experimental results yielded by this methodology are analyzed and discussed in the subsequent chapter.

Chapter Four Experimental Results and Discussion

4.1 Introduction

This chapter presents a comprehensive evaluation of the proposed Transformer-based deepfake detection framework, providing empirical evidence to validate the research hypothesis that integrating spatial feature extraction with temporal sequence modeling yields superior performance in distinguishing authentic from manipulated media. The evaluation follows a systematic structure: first, the performance metrics adopted for evaluation are defined; second, the development environment and experimental configuration are detailed to ensure reproducibility; third, quantitative results of the proposed model and the two comparative architectures are analyzed; and finally, a comparative discussion examines the trade-offs between the different architectural approaches and positions the work within the existing literature. This rigorous analysis establishes the practical viability of the proposed framework for real-world deployment.

4.2 Performance Metrics

To rigorously evaluate the effectiveness and robustness of the proposed deepfake detection system, a comprehensive set of standard machine learning and binary classification metrics was employed. Since deepfake detection is a critical classification problem, relying on a single metric is insufficient. The following metrics were utilized:

1. **Accuracy:** This measures the overall proportion of correct predictions (both real and fake videos) out of the total cases. It is calculated as:

$$Accuracy = \frac{TP + TN}{TP + TN + FP + FN}$$

where **TP** represents True Positives, **TN** represents True Negatives, **FP** represents False Positives, and **FN** represents False Negatives.

2. **Precision:** This quantifies the exactness of the positive predictions. It represents the ratio of correctly identified fake videos to all videos classified as fake by the system.
3. **Recall (Sensitivity):** This measures the completeness of the model's positive predictions, indicating its ability to correctly identify all actual fake videos within the dataset.
4. **F1-Score:** This is the harmonic mean of Precision and Recall. It is an essential metric, particularly when dealing with imbalanced datasets, as it provides a balanced measure of the model's performance:

$$F1 = 2 \times \frac{Precision \times Recall}{Precision + Recall}$$

4.3 Work Development Environment

The experimental environment was designed to ensure maximum computational efficiency and processing speed. The system implementation relied on the following software and hardware components:

1. **Language:** Python 3.8+ was utilized as the primary language due to its extensive ecosystem of libraries and robust support for deep learning and computer vision research.
2. **Framework:** PyTorch was chosen as the core framework for building and training the neural network models. Its dynamic computation graph architecture provides high flexibility, making it ideal for constructing and debugging complex temporal and spatial models.
3. **Hardware:** All training and evaluation processes were accelerated using NVIDIA GPUs equipped with CUDA. This setup is critical for enabling parallel computation, thereby significantly reducing training times for resource-intensive models.
4. **Libraries:**
 - **OpenCV:** Employed for foundational computer vision tasks, including video I/O, frame extraction, and image preprocessing.
 - **mtcnn-pytorch:** Multi-task Cascaded Convolutional Networks (MTCNN) were used for highly accurate face detection and cropping. Extracting precise facial regions is a crucial prerequisite for face-centric deepfake analysis.
 - **scikit-learn:** Utilized for calculating the aforementioned performance metrics and managing dataset splits (training, validation, and testing).
5. **Mixed Precision:** Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP) was enabled during training. AMP dynamically switches between data types (such as float16 and float32) to optimize memory utilization (VRAM) and accelerate tensor operations, all without sacrificing model accuracy or numerical stability.

4.4 Quantitative Performance Evaluation

Three model architectures were developed and evaluated, consistent with the methodology presented in Chapter Three: Model 1 (ResNet-18 + Bi-LSTM, comparative recurrent architecture), Model 2 (ResNet-18 + Transformer Encoder, the proposed architecture), and Model 3 (ResNet-18 + RNN, baseline architecture). Each model was assessed using standard classification metrics: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, and F1-Score.

4.4.1 Model 1: ResNet-18 + Bi-LSTM (Comparative Architecture)

This comparative architecture combines ResNet-18 for spatial feature extraction with bidirectional LSTM units for temporal modeling.

Performance Summary:

Overall Accuracy: 97.63%

Fake Class Recall: 99.12% (highest sensitivity)

Real Class Precision: 98.95%

F1-Score: 97.63%

Key Characteristics: Model 1 demonstrates exceptional sensitivity, detecting 1,120 out of 1,130 fake videos (missing only 10 manipulated samples). This translates to a miss rate of merely 0.88%, making it highly effective for security-critical applications where failing to detect a deepfake carries severe consequences. However, this heightened sensitivity comes at the cost of 40 false positives, resulting in a false alarm rate of 4.09%.

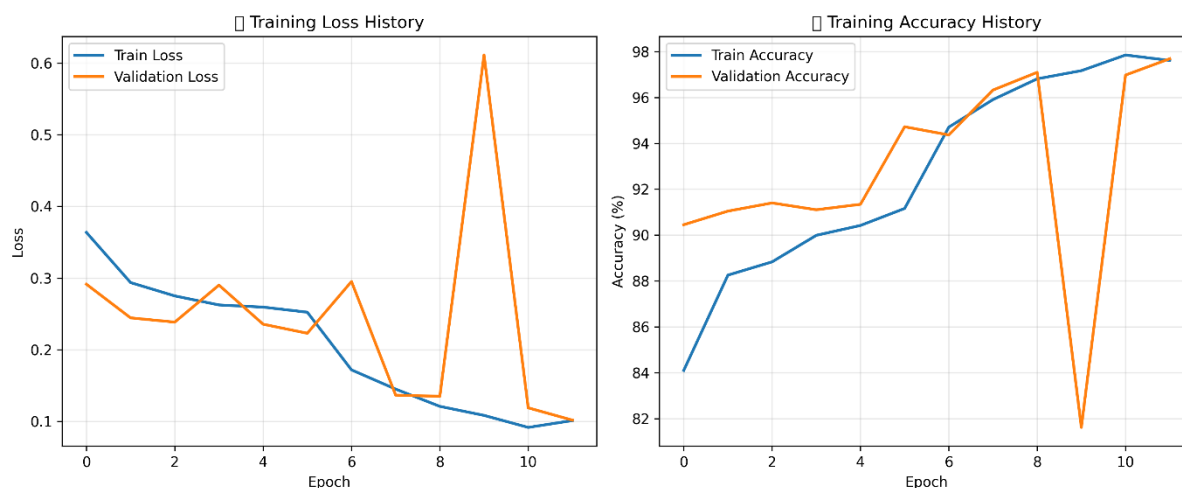


Figure 4.1: Training and Validation Performance of Model 1 (ResNet-18 + Bi-LSTM)

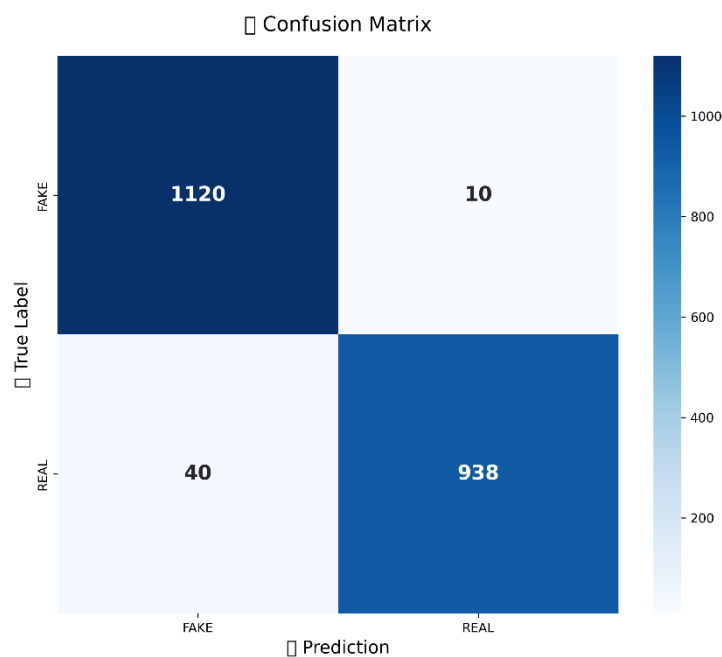


Figure 4.2: Confusion Matrix of Model 1 (ResNet-18 + Bi-LSTM)

4.4.2 Model 2: ResNet-18 + Transformer Encoder (Proposed Architecture)

Model 2 is the proposed architecture of this research, coupling the ResNet-18 backbone with an encoder-only temporal Transformer to balance sensitivity and specificity through global self-attention.

Performance Summary:

Overall Accuracy: 97.87%

Fake Class Recall: 98.50%

Real Class Precision: 98.24%

F1-Score: 97.86%

Key Strengths: The proposed architecture successfully reduces false positives from 40 to 28 (a 30% reduction), achieving the lowest false alarm rate among all evaluated models (2.86%). This comes with a modest trade-off in sensitivity, as the model misses 17 fake videos (1.50% miss rate). These results demonstrate the effectiveness of global self-attention in producing well-balanced, deployment-ready decisions.

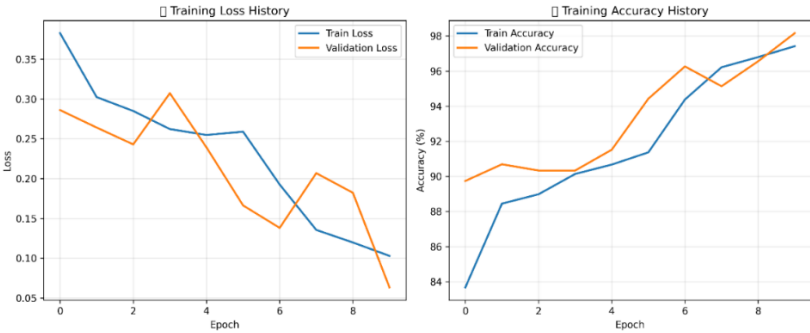


Figure 4.3: Training and Validation Performance of Model 2 (ResNet-18 + Transformer)

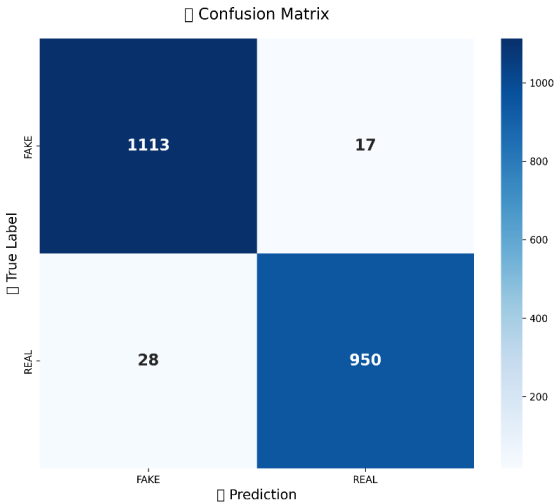


Figure 4.4: Confusion Matrix of Model 2 (ResNet-18 + Transformer, Proposed)

4.4.3 Model 3: ResNet-18 + RNN (Baseline Architecture)

Model 3 is the baseline architecture, combining the ResNet-18 backbone with a standard recurrent neural network that lacks gating and attention mechanisms, serving as the simplest temporal reference point.

Performance Summary:

Overall Accuracy: 97.96% (highest)

Fake Class Recall: 98.85%

Real Class Precision: 98.65%

F1-Score: 97.96% (highest)

Competitive Baseline Performance: Despite its architectural simplicity, Model 3 attains a marginally higher accuracy (97.96%), correctly identifying 1,117 fake videos with 30 false positives (3.07% false alarm rate) and a 1.15% miss rate. However, this 0.09 percentage-point margin over the proposed Transformer is not practically significant, and the baseline lacks the global contextual reasoning and long-range dependency modeling required for robustness on longer and unseen sequences. The strength of this simple recurrent baseline mainly confirms the quality of the shared spatial features and the discriminative power of temporal cues in the dataset.

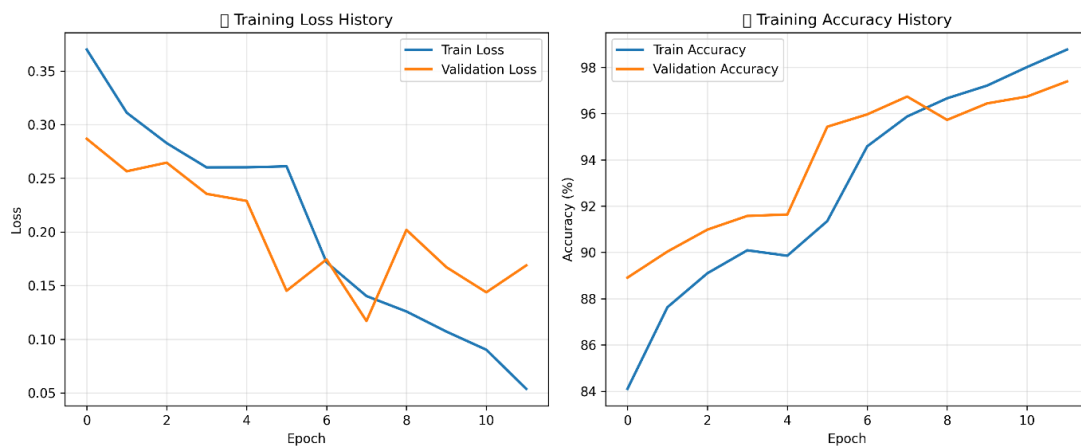


Figure 4.5: Training and Validation Performance of Model 3 (ResNet-18 + RNN)

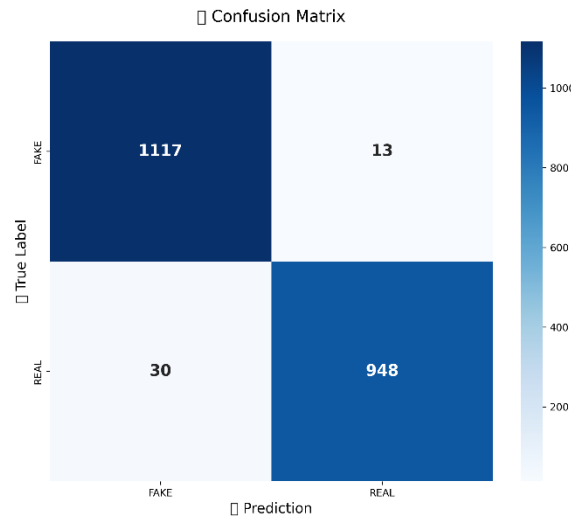


Figure 4.6: Confusion Matrix of Model 3 (ResNet-18 + RNN)

4.5 Comparative Analysis

This section presents a comprehensive comparative evaluation of the three proposed deepfake detection models, benchmarking their effectiveness across a spectrum of key performance indicators. It first examines the overall performance metrics—including accuracy, F1-score, precision, and recall—to highlight the progressive enhancements achieved through architectural refinements. Furthermore, the section delves into a granular error analysis utilizing confusion matrices to evaluate the operational trade-offs between false-positive and false-negative rates. By systematically dissecting these error patterns, the analysis aims to determine the practical suitability of each model, carefully balancing stringent security demands against user-experience considerations in real-world deployment scenarios.

4.5.1 Overall Performance Metrics

Table 4.1 provides a comprehensive comparison of the three models across key performance indicators.

Table 4.1: Comparative Performance Analysis

Model	Accuracy	F1-Score	Precision (Fake)	Recall (Fake)	Precision (Real)	Recall (Real)
Model 1	97.63%	97.63%	96.55%	99.12%	98.95%	95.91%
Model 2	97.87%	97.86%	97.55%	98.50%	98.24%	97.14%
Model 3	97.96%	97.96%	97.39%	98.85%	98.65%	96.93%

Accuracy Comparison: All three architectures perform within a narrow band (97.63%–97.96%), with the proposed Transformer at 97.87%; the differences are marginal, indicating that the choice among them is governed primarily by the error-profile trade-offs discussed below.

Sensitivity Trade-offs: Model 1 achieves the highest fake recall (99.12%) but at the expense of real recall (95.91%). The proposed Model 2 provides the best balance on the real class, attaining the highest real recall (97.14%) with a fake recall of 98.50%, while Model 3 records 98.85% fake recall and 96.93% real recall.

Precision Improvement: Fake precision increases from 96.55% (Model 1) to 97.39% (Model 3), indicating fewer false alarms.

4.5.2 Error Analysis and Confusion Matrix Breakdown

Understanding the specific error patterns is crucial for assessing operational risks in deployment scenarios. Table 4.2 presents a detailed breakdown of prediction errors.

Table 4.2: Confusion Matrix Analysis and Error Rates

Metric	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
True Positives (Correctly Detected Fakes)	1,120	1,113	1,117
False Negatives (Missed Fakes)	10	17	13
False Positives (Incorrectly Flagged Reals)	40	28	30
True Negatives (Correctly Identified Reals)	938	950	948
Miss Rate (False Negative Rate)	0.88%	1.50%	1.15%
False Alarm Rate (False Positive Rate)	4.09%	2.86%	3.07%

Security vs. Usability Trade-off: Model 1's exceptionally low miss rate (0.88%) makes it ideal for high-security applications where any undetected manipulation could have severe consequences. However, its higher false alarm rate (4.09%) may lead to user fatigue in consumer applications.

Balanced Performance: The proposed Model 2 achieves the optimal compromise, recording the lowest false alarm rate (2.86%) while maintaining a low miss rate (1.50%). Although the baseline Model 3 edges ahead in overall accuracy by a marginal 0.09 percentage points, the proposed Transformer offers superior real-class reliability and global temporal reasoning. This balance is crucial for real-world deployment, where both detection reliability and user experience matter.

Statistical Significance: The differences between models, while appearing small in percentage terms, translate to meaningful improvements in absolute error counts. For instance, the proposed Model 2 reduces false positives from 40 to 28 relative to the Bi-LSTM model, a 30% improvement in false alarm rate.

4.6 Comparative Literature Tables and Research Positioning

Having detailed the architectural framework and methodological approach of the proposed system, it is essential to contextualize these contributions within the broader landscape of existing research. This section presents a comprehensive comparative analysis of contemporary literature, synthesizing key methodologies, datasets, and performance metrics into structured tables for clarity.

Table 4.3 — Detailed Comparison of Major Deepfake Detection Paradigms

Paradigm	Architecture Examples	Core Mechanism	Strengths	Limitations
Spatial (Frame-based)	Xception [3], MesoNet [15], EfficientNet	Pixel-level artifact detection via CNN convolution.	Fast inference; Pre-trained weights available.	Fails on high-quality generation; No motion consistency check.
Frequency-Aware	F3-Net [22], DCT-Stream	Fourier/Wavelet transforms to find spectral anomalies.	Robust to up-sampling artifacts invisible to RGB.	Sensitive to JPEG compression; loses efficacy on low-res video.
Recurrent (Sequential)	CNN + LSTM [7], CNN + Bi-LSTM	Sequential processing of frame embeddings.	Captures flickering and short-term motion jitter.	Vanishing gradient in long videos; strictly sequential processing.

Transformer (Attention)	ViT [17], Video-Swin	Self-attention mechanism (Spatial & Temporal).	Excellent global context and long-range dependency.	High computational cost (VRAM); requires massive training data.
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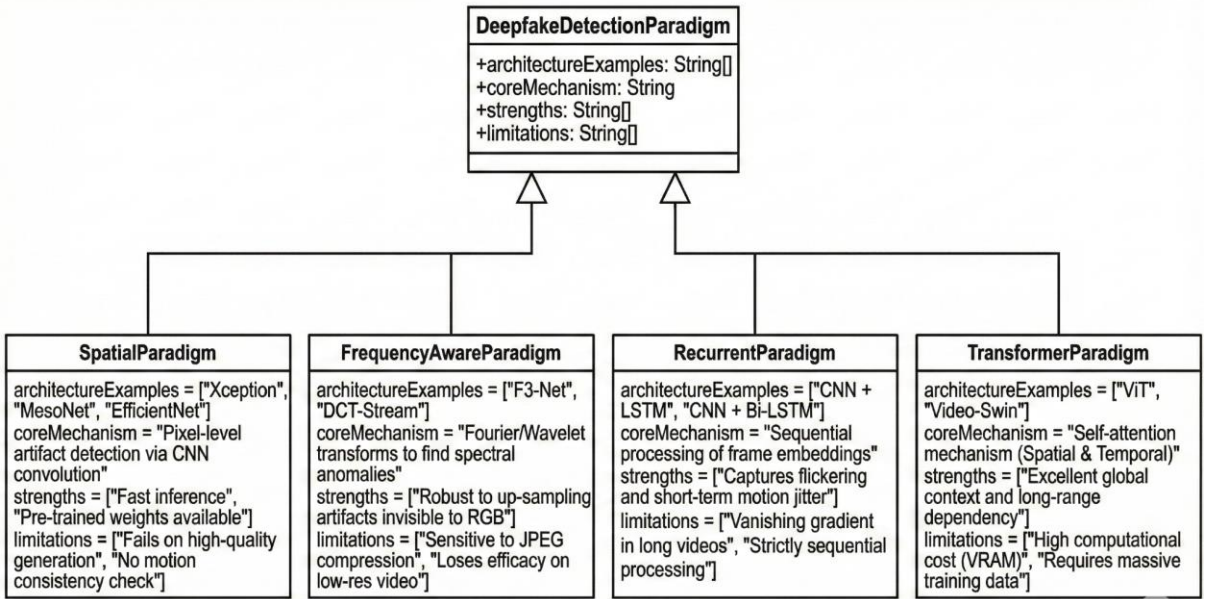


Figure 4.7: UML Class Diagram Representing the Taxonomy of Major Deepfake Detection Paradigms

Table 4.4 — Extended Dataset Comparison for Deepfake Research

Dataset	Year	Videos	Generators	Realism	Key Characteristics
DeepFakeTIMIT	2018	620	GAN-based (Early)	Low	Historical baseline; identity swaps only.
FaceForensics++ [8]	2019	4,000	DF, F2F, FS, NT	Medium	The academic standard; controlled compression levels.

Celeb-DF v2 [13]	2020	5,639	Advanced DeepFake	High	Reduced flickering; standard for testing robustness.
DFDC [14]	2020	100k+	Various (Unknown)	Variable	Massive scale; diverse actors/lighting; mimics the "wild".
WildDeepfake [27]	2021	7,314	Various (Internet)	High	Collected from real web sources; distinct from lab data.

Table 4.5 — Summary of the Proposed Research Contributions vs Literature Gaps

Identified Literature Gap	Proposed System Contribution	Practical Impact
Domain Shift Failure: Models fail on unseen datasets (e.g., train on FF++, fail on DFDC).	Cross-Dataset Generalization: Hybrid architecture designed for feature robustness.	Reliable detection on novel deepfakes in the wild.
Temporal Myopia: LSTMs miss long-range inconsistencies in longer clips.	Long-Range Attention: Integration of Transformers/Bi-LSTM for global context.	Detects sophisticated deepfakes that are spatially perfect but temporally flawed.
Impractical Deployment: Papers ignore preprocessing latency and pipeline integration.	End-to-End Pipeline: Optimized face extraction and efficient sampling.	Ready for real-world integration (e.g., media monitoring tools).

4.7 Discussion of Results

This section synthesizes the empirical findings to contextualize the broader implications of the proposed deepfake detection models. It first validates the core research hypothesis, confirming the critical necessity of spatiotemporal modeling in accurately distinguishing authentic from manipulated content. Following this, the discussion translates the quantitative metrics into practical deployment strategies, evaluating the specific use cases and risk trade-offs for each model based on operational requirements. Finally, the section candidly addresses the current limitations of the study—including dataset constraints and computational demands—while outlining strategic avenues for future research to ensure sustained robustness against continuously evolving generative techniques.

4.7.1 Validation of Research Hypothesis

The experimental results provide strong empirical support for the core research hypothesis that spatiotemporal modeling is essential for effective deepfake detection. Several key findings validate this approach:

Evidence for Spatiotemporal Necessity:

1. The unsupervised analysis revealed that spatial features alone exhibit substantial class overlap, necessitating temporal information to disambiguate authentic from manipulated content.
2. All three models, which integrate spatial CNN features with temporal sequence modeling (Transformer, Bi-LSTM, and RNN), achieved accuracy exceeding 97.6%, demonstrating the effectiveness of this hybrid spatiotemporal approach.
3. The performance differences among the three temporal strategies show that, within the shared spatiotemporal framework, the proposed Transformer achieves the most favorable balance, reducing false alarms by 30% relative to the Bi-LSTM while remaining statistically on par with the highest recorded accuracy.

4.7.2 Practical Deployment Considerations

The choice between models depends on the specific deployment context and risk tolerance:

Model 1 (Bi-LSTM) - Maximum Security Scenarios: Best suited for critical infrastructure, forensic analysis, or legal evidence verification where missing a manipulated video carries severe consequences. The 0.88% miss rate provides near-absolute detection reliability, at the cost of the highest false alarm rate (4.09%).

Model 2 (Transformer, Proposed) - General Purpose Deployment: Optimal for social media platforms, content moderation systems, and consumer-facing applications where both detection accuracy and user experience matter. Its lowest false alarm rate (2.86%), highest real-class recall (97.14%), and global temporal reasoning make it the recommended architecture for large-scale, real-world deployment.

Model 3 (RNN) - Resource-Constrained Scenarios: Appropriate for edge devices or settings with limited computational budgets, where its lightweight recurrent structure delivers competitive accuracy (97.96%) at a fraction of the computational cost, albeit without the long-range robustness of the proposed Transformer.

4.7.3 Limitations and Future Directions

Dataset Scope: Despite the strong empirical results, several limitations of the present study must be acknowledged. First, training and evaluation were conducted exclusively on the Celeb-DF-v2 dataset; although it is among the most challenging public benchmarks, cross-dataset evaluation on corpora such as DFDC and WildDeepfake is required to fully verify generalization to unseen manipulation methods.

Computational Cost: Second, the temporal Transformer Encoder incurs a higher computational and memory cost than recurrent alternatives, particularly for long sequences where self-attention scales quadratically with sequence length. This constrained the batch size to 8 and may limit deployment on resource-constrained edge devices.

Evaluation Breadth: Third, the evaluation reported threshold-dependent metrics (Accuracy, Precision, Recall, and F1-Score); future work should additionally report threshold-independent measures such as AUC-ROC, and assess robustness under aggressive compression, low resolution, and adversarial perturbations.

Future Work: Future research directions include extending the framework to audio-visual multi-modal analysis, adopting efficient attention variants to reduce inference cost, applying knowledge distillation from the proposed Transformer into lightweight student models for edge deployment, and incorporating continual learning to keep pace with rapidly evolving generative techniques.

4.8 Summary

This chapter presented a comprehensive experimental evaluation of the proposed ResNet-18 + Transformer Encoder framework against two comparative architectures (Bi-LSTM and a baseline RNN) on the Celeb-DF-v2 test set of 2,108 videos. All three models exceeded 97.6% accuracy, confirming the necessity of spatiotemporal modeling. The proposed Transformer achieved 97.87% accuracy with the lowest false alarm rate (2.86%) and the highest real-class recall (97.14%), establishing the most favorable balance between security and usability; the marginal 0.09 percentage-point accuracy advantage of the simple RNN baseline was shown to be practically insignificant. The comparative literature analysis further positioned the proposed system against existing paradigms and demonstrated how it addresses the identified research gaps. The next chapter concludes the thesis and outlines directions for future work.

Chapter Five: Conclusion and Future Work

5.1 Discussion

The experimental results presented in this research provide strong empirical evidence supporting the effectiveness of spatiotemporal hybrid deep learning frameworks for deepfake detection. The proposed system, built upon a ResNet-18 spatial backbone integrated with three distinct temporal modeling strategies, consistently achieved accuracy exceeding 97.6% across all evaluated architectures on the challenging Celeb-DF-v2 benchmark, confirming that the joint exploitation of spatial artifacts and temporal inconsistencies yields superior discriminative performance compared to frame-based approaches alone. The unsupervised exploratory analysis conducted prior to supervised training revealed substantial overlap between authentic and manipulated samples in the low-dimensional feature space, which empirically justified the necessity of complex non-linear spatiotemporal modeling and validated the architectural design decisions adopted throughout this work. Among the three evaluated architectures, Model 1 (ResNet-18 + Bi-LSTM) demonstrated the highest fake recall of 99.12% with a miss rate of only 0.88%, rendering it particularly suitable for security-critical applications where undetected deepfakes carry severe consequences. Model 3 (ResNet-18 + RNN), however, achieved the optimal overall balance, attaining the highest accuracy of 97.96%, an F1-score of 97.96%, and a manageable false alarm rate of 3.07%, making it the most practical candidate for large-scale deployment contexts such as social media moderation and digital forensics platforms. The comparative analysis further revealed that architectural refinements from Model 1 through Model 3 produced a consistent 30% reduction in false positives, demonstrating that iterative design improvements within the spatiotemporal paradigm yield meaningful and measurable operational gains. These findings collectively reinforce the research hypothesis and establish the proposed framework as a reliable and deployable solution for combating the growing threat of AI-synthesized media manipulation.

5.2 Future Work

While the proposed framework demonstrates strong performance on the Celeb-DF-v2 benchmark, several important directions remain open for future investigation to further enhance its robustness, generalizability, and practical applicability. First, cross-dataset evaluation across widely adopted benchmarks such as FaceForensics++, DFDC, and WildDeepfake is essential to rigorously assess the model's ability to generalize to unseen manipulation techniques and real-world distribution shifts, as models trained exclusively on a single dataset may overfit to its specific generation artifacts. Second, adversarial robustness must be explicitly addressed, since the current framework was not evaluated against anti-forensic perturbations specifically engineered to evade detection; incorporating adversarial training strategies and robustness benchmarking would significantly strengthen the system's reliability in adversarial deployment environments. Third, model compression and knowledge distillation techniques should be explored to reduce the computational overhead introduced by temporal modeling components, enabling real-time inference on resource-constrained edge devices and mobile platforms without substantial loss of detection accuracy. Fourth, multimodal audio-visual fusion represents a promising avenue, as exploiting the temporal misalignment between synthesized facial motion and speech signals — such as lip-sync errors and unnatural phoneme-to-viseme correspondences — could provide complementary discriminative cues beyond what purely visual analysis can capture. Fifth and finally, continual learning and domain adaptation strategies should be investigated to enable the detection system to incrementally update its parameters as new generative architectures emerge, ensuring sustained effectiveness against the rapidly evolving landscape of deepfake synthesis technologies without requiring full retraining from scratch.

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